Project Planning: Scope, Timeline & Risk (Day 12)

Expense Tracker App – Project Plan & Risk Register

1. Project Objective

Deliver a cross-platform (Android and iOS) personal expense tracker app to public release by 8 April 2027, within a USD 60,000 budget, that lets a user record an expense in under 15 seconds and see where their money goes each month.

The objective is considered met when all of the following hold:

- Version 1.0 is live on Google Play and the Apple App Store by 8 April 2027.
- All Must-have features (see Scope) pass acceptance testing with zero open critical defects.
- Total spend stays within USD 60,000 (10% contingency included).
- Within 60 days of launch: at least 1,000 installs and an average store rating of 4.0 or higher.

Project context assumed for this plan: a five-person team (project manager, 2 Frontend developers, 2 backend developer, 1 UI/UX designer and QA shared part-time) starting 2 November 2026.

2. Scope

Version 1.0 covers manual expense tracking, budgets and basic reporting on mobile. Anything not listed under In Scope is out of scope unless it goes through change control.

In scope

- User registration, login and password reset (email and password)
- Add, edit and delete expenses (amount, category, date, note, optional receipt photo)
- Default and custom categories
- Monthly budgets per category with an alert at 80% and 100% of the limit
- Dashboard with monthly totals, category pie chart and 6-month trend
- Search and filter expenses by date, category and amount
- Export expenses to CSV
- Cloud sync and backup so data survives a phone change
- Android and iOS apps built from one cross-platform codebase
- Unit, integration and user acceptance testing, plus store submission
- User guide, privacy policy and 4 weeks of post-launch bug-fix support

Out of scope

- Automatic bank account linking or SMS and email parsing of transactions
- Multi-currency conversion and live exchange rates
- Shared or family accounts and group expense splitting
- Invoicing, tax filing or accounting-software integration
- AI-based spending predictions and advice

- Web and desktop versions, smartwatch apps
- Multi-language support (English only in v1.0)
- Paid subscriptions, in-app purchases and advertising

3. Work Breakdown Structure (WBS)

The WBS splits the project into 7 top-level deliverables, each broken down to three levels (Level 1 > Level 2 > Level 3). It follows the 100% rule: the Level 1 elements add up to the whole scope in section 2, each parent equals the sum of its children, and nothing outside the scope appears. Every timeline, cost and resource estimate in this project is built from the Level 3 work packages.

1 Project Management

1.1 Initiation
- 1.1.1 Project charter
- 1.1.2 Stakeholder register
- 1.1.3 Kickoff meeting

1.2 Planning
- 1.2.1 Project plan and WBS
- 1.2.2 Risk register
- 1.2.3 Communication plan

1.3 Monitoring and control
- 1.3.1 Weekly status reports
- 1.3.2 Change log
- 1.3.3 Risk and plan reviews

1.4 Closure
- 1.4.1 Final report
- 1.4.2 Lessons learned
- 1.4.3 Handover to support

2 Requirements and Analysis

2.1 Requirements gathering
- 2.1.1 User survey and interviews
- 2.1.2 Competitor analysis
- 2.1.3 User stories

2.2 Requirements specification
- 2.2.1 Prioritised feature list (MoSCoW)
- 2.2.2 Acceptance criteria
- 2.2.3 Signed-off requirements document

3 Design

3.1 UX design
- 3.1.1 User flows
- 3.1.2 Wireframes
- 3.1.3 Clickable prototype

3.2 UI design
- 3.2.1 Style guide and components
- 3.2.2 Final screen designs

- 3.2.3 Developer hand-off files

3.3 Technical design

- 3.3.1 System architecture
- 3.3.2 Database schema
- 3.3.3 API specification

4 Backend Development

4.1 Accounts and security

- 4.1.1 Registration and login API
- 4.1.2 Password reset
- 4.1.3 Security hardening

4.2 Expense services

- 4.2.1 Expense create, read, update, delete API
- 4.2.2 Category and budget API
- 4.2.3 Reports and aggregation API

4.3 Infrastructure

- 4.3.1 Cloud environment setup
- 4.3.2 CI/CD pipeline
- 4.3.3 Backups and monitoring

5 Mobile App Development

5.1 Foundation

- 5.1.1 Project setup and navigation
- 5.1.2 Login and registration screens
- 5.1.3 Local storage and cloud sync

5.2 Core features

- 5.2.1 Add and edit expense
- 5.2.2 Categories and budgets with alerts
- 5.2.3 Search and filter

5.3 Insights and settings

- 5.3.1 Dashboard and charts
- 5.3.2 CSV export
- 5.3.3 Settings and profile

6 Testing and Quality Assurance

6.1 Test planning

- 6.1.1 Test plan
- 6.1.2 Test cases
- 6.1.3 Test data and devices

6.2 Test execution

- 6.2.1 Unit and integration testing
- 6.2.2 System and device testing
- 6.2.3 Security and performance testing

6.3 User acceptance testing (UAT)

- 6.3.1 Beta group recruitment
- 6.3.2 UAT execution
- 6.3.3 Defect fixing, retest and sign-off

7 Release and Launch

7.1 Store preparation

- 7.1.1 Developer accounts
- 7.1.2 Store listing assets
- 7.1.3 Privacy policy and compliance check

7.2 Deployment

- 7.2.1 Production release build
- 7.2.2 Store submission and review
- 7.2.3 Go-live checklist

7.3 Post-launch support

- 7.3.1 User guide
- 7.3.2 Four weeks of bug-fix support
- 7.3.3 Feedback and ratings monitoring

4. Key Milestones

The project runs 2 November 2026 to 6 May 2027 (27 weeks), with public launch on 8 April 2027. Each milestone is a checkpoint with evidence, not just a date.

#	Milestone	Target date	Evidence it is done
M1	Kickoff done, plan baselined	Nov 5, 2026	Charter, project plan and risk register approved by sponsor
M2	Requirements signed off	Nov 19, 2026	Signed requirements document with MoSCoW priorities
M3	Design approved	Dec 17, 2026	Clickable prototype, architecture and API spec approved
M4	Backend APIs complete	Jan 28, 2027	All APIs pass integration tests on the staging server
M5	Mobile app feature complete	Feb 25, 2027	All Must-have features working on Android and iOS test builds
M6	Testing and UAT sign-off	Mar 18, 2027	Zero open critical defects; beta users approve

#	Milestone	Target date	Evidence it is done
M7	Store submission	Mar 25, 2027	App submitted to Google Play and the App Store
M8	Public launch (v1.0 live)	Apr 8, 2027	App downloadable in both stores
M9	Project closure	May 6, 2027	Support period ended, lessons learned and final report delivered

5. Assumptions, Constraints and Dependencies

Assumptions are things we treat as true without proof, constraints are fixed limits, and dependencies are things we need from outside a task before it can start or finish. Each assumption is checked at the milestone shown.

Assumptions

- The team of five is available at the planned allocation from 2 November 2026 (checked at M1).
- A single cross-platform framework (for example Flutter or React Native) meets all performance needs (checked at M3).
- The sponsor and product owner respond to review requests within 2 working days.
- Requirements will not grow after sign-off at M2 except through approved change requests.
- Cloud hosting and developer accounts cost no more than the budgeted USD 4,000.
- At least 30 volunteers can be recruited for beta testing (checked before M6).

Constraints

- **Budget:** USD 60,000 fixed, including a 10% contingency reserve.
- **Time:** public launch no later than 8 April 2027.
- **Resources:** five-person core team, QA shared part-time; no extra hires.
- **Platform rules:** the app must follow Google Play and Apple App Store policies and data privacy rules.
- **Scope:** v1.0 is limited to the in-scope list; no bank integration.
- **Quality:** zero open critical defects at release.

Dependencies

Dependency	Type	Needed by	Impact if late
Signed requirements (M2) before design starts	Internal	M2	Design and everything after it shifts

Dependency	Type	Needed by	Impact if late
Approved designs and API spec before development	Internal	M3	Mobile and backend work cannot start
Backend staging APIs before mobile integration	Internal	M4	Mobile screens cannot be tested end to end
Apple Developer and Google Play accounts approved	External	Before M7	Store submission blocked
App Store and Google Play review process (about 1 to 2 weeks)	External	M7 to M8	Launch date slips
Cloud hosting provider and email service availability	External	M4	Backend cannot be deployed
Beta testers recruited and available	External	M6	UAT sign-off delayed

6. Risk Register

This register lists 10 risks, highest score first. A risk is an uncertain event that might happen; once it happens it becomes an issue and moves to the issue log. Score = Probability x Impact, with High = 3, Medium = 2, Low = 1. Scores of 6 to 9 are High priority, 3 to 4 Medium, and 1 to 2 Low. The register is reviewed every week in the status meeting.

ID	Risk description	Prob.	Impact	Score	Response strategy and action	Owner
R1	Scope creep: stakeholders ask for extra features (for example bank linking) after requirement	High	High	9	**Avoid.** Freeze scope at M2, keep the out-of-scope list visible, and route every new request through	Project Manager

ID	Risk description	Prob.	Impact	Score	Response strategy and action	Owner
	s sign-off, causing delay and cost overrun.				change control.	
R2	A key developer (mobile or backend) leaves or is unavailable for 2 or more weeks, stalling development.	Medium	High	6	**Mitigate.** Pair programming, code documentation and cross-training from week 1; line up a freelancer on standby.	Project Manager
R3	Google Play or App Store rejects the app or the review takes longer than 2 weeks (privacy policy, permissions).	Medium	High	6	**Mitigate.** Check store guidelines at design stage, prepare the privacy policy early, and submit at M7, two weeks before launch.	Release Lead
R4	Development effort is underestimated (sync and charts are complex), so milestones	High	Medium	6	**Mitigate.** Use three-point estimates, add a 15% schedule buffer, track progress weekly, and	Tech Lead

ID	Risk description	Prob.	Impact	Score	Response strategy and action	Owner
	M4 and M5 slip.				drop Should-have features first if needed.	
R5	Bugs on many Android devices and iOS versions are found late in testing.	High	Medium	6	**Mitigate.** Define a device test matrix at M3, use a cloud device farm, and start device testing at M5, not at the end.	QA Lead
R6	Low adoption after launch: fewer than 1,000 installs or a rating below 4.0 in 60 days.	Medium	Medium	4	**Mitigate.** Run a beta group, simple onboarding, and a pre-launch landing page; act on beta feedback before M7.	Product Owner
R7	Budget overrun from rework, tools or hosting costs beyond USD 60,000.	Medium	Medium	4	**Accept (with reserve).** Hold the 10% contingency reserve, track cost weekly, and escalate to the sponsor	Project Manager

ID	Risk description	Prob.	Impact	Score	Response strategy and action	Owner
					if spend passes 90%.	
R8	Security breach exposes users' financial data.	Low	High	3	**Transfer and mitigate.** Use a managed authentication service from the cloud provider, encrypt data in transit and at rest, and run security testing in task 6.2.3.	Backend Developer
R9	Minor cosmetic defects remain at launch because of time pressure.	High	Low	3	**Accept.** Log them with low priority and fix them in v1.1; critical and major defects must still be zero at launch.	Product Owner
R10	Cloud hosting or email service outage or price change during build	Low	Medium	2	**Transfer.** Choose a provider with a written uptime guarantee (SLA), keep automated	Backend Developer

ID	Risk description	Prob.	Impact	Score	Response strategy and action	Owner
	or after launch.				backups, and review pricing at M3.	

7. Note: Why Planning Is Not a One-Time Activity

A project plan is a record of what we knew on the day we wrote it, and that knowledge starts going out of date the next morning. Requirements change, people get sick, estimates prove wrong, and risks in the register either disappear or turn into real issues. A plan that is written once and filed away stops describing the project, so decisions get made from memory and guesswork instead.

The document and the thinking are different things. The document (this plan) is only a snapshot; the planning is the ongoing thinking that keeps asking what has changed, what could go wrong next, and what should we do about it. That thinking is a continuous responsibility of the project manager, and it happens in weekly risk reviews, status reports, change-request decisions and re-estimates at each milestone. When something moves, the PM updates the WBS, the schedule, the risk register and the stakeholders together, and keeps a baseline to compare against.

In this project, for example, if the App Store review takes longer than expected (R3) or scope grows after M2 (R1), the launch date and budget have to be re-planned straight away, and the sponsor told early. Teams that plan continuously find problems while they are still cheap to fix; teams that plan once find them at the deadline.